

—which now forms the heart of her work—began three years later, when she was invited by British singer Jane Manning (“the patron saint of new vocal music,” according to Weir) to write a piece for solo soprano. The result was *King Harald’s Saga* (1979), which revealed her ability to compress a historical epic into less than 10 minutes and to represent a huge cast by a lone voice.

Her first work for theater came in 1985, with the creepy one-act opera, *The Black Spider*. But it was two years later that Weir drew widespread attention with the premiere of her three-act opera *A Night at the Chinese Opera*. The menacing play-within-a-play was inspired by her reading of 14th-century Chinese drama; it became one of her most popular works.



MISS FORTUNE, COVENT GARDEN

Miss Fortune was staged at the Royal Opera House in London in 2012. Weir’s opera brings a modern context—including a setting in a laundromat—to the Sicilian folk tale on which it is based.

Expressive power

This was followed by *The Vanishing Bridegroom* (1990), which draws on, and greatly enlivens, dark folk tales from the western Highlands of Scotland. Among Weir’s other most successful